

## **Transcript - DOE Daily News Briefing Podcast**

**Tuesday, December 16, 2025**

Good morning. This is your DOE Daily News Briefing for Tuesday, December 16, 2025.

Today's briefing covers key developments in federal energy policy, grid reliability, nuclear energy, industry and market activity, cybersecurity, scientific research, and global energy dynamics relevant to the Department of Energy. We begin with the top energy headlines shaping today's landscape.

### **OPENING HEADLINES**

- Energy Secretary Chris Wright says electricity prices are expected to decline under current energy policies, as new generation and infrastructure come online.
- The Energy Secretary is calling for broad reforms to the federal environmental permitting process, arguing that the current law is slowing critical energy and infrastructure projects.
- Utilities across the country report surging demand from data centers and large power users, intensifying pressure on aging electric grids.
- Global energy markets are reacting to geopolitical developments as oil prices fall below sixty dollars amid Russia-Ukraine peace talks.

### **FEDERAL & DOE-CENTRIC COVERAGE**

Energy Secretary Chris Wright said electricity prices will begin to stabilize and decline under the Trump administration's energy policies, citing efforts to expand domestic energy supply and reverse regulatory actions he says contributed to rising costs. Speaking in a televised interview, Wright acknowledged continued short-term price pressure but said the Department expects price relief as new energy projects move forward.

The Energy Secretary is also urging Congress to enact broad-based reforms to the National Environmental Policy Act, or NEPA, calling the 55-year-old law a major barrier to building energy infrastructure. Wright said the law has shifted from a safeguard into a source of prolonged delays and litigation, slowing the development of pipelines, transmission lines, and power generation projects critical to U.S. energy reliability and competitiveness.

### **STATES & DOMESTIC ENERGY IMPLEMENTATION**

In New York, National Grid reports that requests from large power users seeking to connect to the electric grid have tripled in just one year. The utility says demand driven by artificial intelligence, data centers, and advanced manufacturing could reach ten gigawatts over the

next five years. Officials say they face a growing challenge balancing grid reliability, infrastructure investment, and rising customer costs.

## **INDUSTRY, INFRASTRUCTURE & MARKETS**

An investor group led by Kimmeridge Energy Management has made a six-billion-dollar offer to acquire Ascent Resources, one of the largest privately held natural gas producers in the United States. The proposed deal underscores the ongoing consolidation and strategic positioning within the domestic gas sector, particularly as natural gas assumes a growing role in electricity generation and grid stability.

Separately, the U.S. Treasury has rejected a bid from Xtellus Partners for foreign assets belonging to Russia's Lukoil. The decision comes as multiple U.S. and international firms remain in competition for the assets, which include oil and gas projects, refining capacity, and thousands of fuel stations worldwide. The move reflects ongoing U.S. sanctions policy tied to Russia's war in Ukraine.

## **GLOBAL ENERGY & GEOPOLITICS**

The United States is pressing the European Union to exempt U.S. oil and gas exports from the bloc's methane emissions reporting requirements until at least 2035. Administration officials argue the regulation poses a non-tariff trade barrier that could disrupt U.S. gas supplies to Europe, particularly as European nations continue reducing reliance on Russian energy.

Meanwhile, the European Union has adopted new sanctions targeting Russia's so-called shadow fleet of oil tankers. The measures aim to limit Moscow's ability to circumvent Western sanctions and continue exporting oil that helps fund the war in Ukraine.

## **OIL & GAS MARKETS**

Oil prices fell below sixty dollars per barrel, reaching their lowest level since May, as markets reacted to signs of progress in Russia-Ukraine peace negotiations and weak economic data from China. Analysts say expectations of increased supply and easing sanctions are weighing on prices, even as geopolitical uncertainty remains high.

## **ELECTRICITY & CYBERSECURITY**

The Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency has released updated cybersecurity performance goals for critical infrastructure operators, including utilities. The revised benchmarks emphasize governance, supply-chain risk management, zero-trust architecture, and incident-response coordination, reflecting lessons learned from recent cyber threats targeting the energy sector.

In a separate discussion on grid demand, National Grid's New York president warned that rapid growth in AI data centers and manufacturing is significantly increasing pressure on the electric system, reinforcing the need for grid modernization and careful cost management.

## **DOE NATIONAL LABORATORIES & SCIENCE**

Fermi National Accelerator Laboratory has named Norbert Holtkamp as its new director. Holtkamp brings extensive experience managing large-scale scientific infrastructure and is expected to lead the laboratory as it advances particle physics research and major accelerator projects.

Fusion startup Thea Energy has completed a preconceptual design for its Helios fusion power plant as part of the Department of Energy's Milestone-Based Fusion Development Program. The company says the design outlines a practical path toward future fusion energy generation using advanced stellarator technology.

Oak Ridge National Laboratory and partner national labs have launched a multi-year collaboration with the University of Tennessee to advance quantum materials research using exascale computing. The effort aims to deepen understanding of materials behavior under extreme conditions, with potential applications across energy and advanced technology sectors.

Sandia National Laboratories is also developing new materials for hypersonic flight, focusing on thermal protection systems that can withstand extreme temperatures and pressures.

Additionally, Virgin Galactic has partnered with Lawrence Livermore National Laboratory to study high-altitude image-capture technology, exploring how commercial launch vehicles could support advanced sensing and data-collection missions.

## **NUCLEAR ENERGY**

The Nuclear Regulatory Commission has approved license extensions allowing the Browns Ferry nuclear plant in Alabama to operate into the mid-2050s. The decision supports long-term carbon-free electricity generation and grid reliability across the Tennessee Valley region.

## **ENVIRONMENTAL MANAGEMENT & NUCLEAR WASTE**

The Department of Energy has awarded a three-year contract extension to the Bechtel-led Salado Isolation Mining Contractors team to continue managing the Waste Isolation Pilot

Plant in New Mexico. DOE officials say the site has exceeded waste-shipment targets and completed major infrastructure upgrades under the current contract.

Meanwhile, the Defense Nuclear Facilities Safety Board has identified a potential bottleneck in waste processing at the Hanford Site's vitrification facility. The board warned that inefficiencies could interrupt operations unless addressed, even as DOE continues progress on immobilizing radioactive tank waste.

## **WHAT TO WATCH**

Today, attention will remain on congressional momentum around permitting reform, rising electricity demand from AI and large power users, cybersecurity expectations for utilities, and global energy market reactions to geopolitical developments.

## **OUTRO**

That concludes today's DOE Daily News Briefing. A full transcript and source list are available in today's SharePoint folder. We'll continue monitoring developments across energy policy, markets, science, and national security. Thank you for listening.

## **SOURCES (IN ORDER OF MENTION)**

### **Federal & DOE-Centric Coverage**

**Fox News** — *Trump administration's top 'scientific priority is AI,' energy secretary says*

<https://www.foxnews.com/video/6386475683112>

**The Hill** — *Energy secretary predicts electricity prices will fall under Trump policies*

<https://thehill.com/policy/energy-environment/5648658-energy-secretary-predicts-lower-prices/>

**Reuters** — *U.S. energy chief calls for NEPA reform to speed infrastructure projects*

<https://www.reuters.com/world/us/us-energy-chief-calls-nepa-reform-speed-infrastructure-projects-2025-12-16/>

### **States & Domestic Energy Implementation**

**Reuters** — *New York grid faces surge in power demand from data centers*

<https://www.reuters.com/business/energy/new-york-grid-faces-surge-power-demand-data-centers-2025-12-16/>

### **Industry, Infrastructure & Markets**

**Reuters** — *Kimmeridge-led group bids \$6 billion for Ascent Resources*

<https://www.reuters.com/business/energy/kimmeridge-led-group-bids-6-billion-ascent-resources-2025-12-16/>

**Reuters** — *U.S. Treasury blocks bid for Lukoil assets*

<https://www.reuters.com/business/energy/us-treasury-blocks-bid-lukoil-assets-2025-12-16/>

### **Global Energy & Geopolitics**

**Reuters** — *U.S. presses EU to exempt LNG exports from methane rules*

<https://www.reuters.com/world/us/us-presses-eu-exempt-lng-exports-methane-rules-2025-12-16/>

**Reuters** — *EU targets Russia's shadow fleet in new oil sanctions*

<https://www.reuters.com/world/europe/eu-targets-russias-shadow-fleet-new-oil-sanctions-2025-12-16/>

### **Oil & Gas Markets**

**Reuters** — *Oil prices slide below \$60 as Russia-Ukraine talks ease supply fears*  
<https://www.reuters.com/business/energy/oil-prices-slide-below-60-russia-ukraine-talks-2025-12-16/>

## **Electricity & Cybersecurity**

**Reuters** — *U.S. cyber agency updates security goals for critical infrastructure*  
<https://www.reuters.com/world/us/us-cyber-agency-updates-security-goals-critical-infrastructure-2025-12-16/>

**Reuters** — *National Grid warns of mounting pressure from AI-driven demand*  
<https://www.reuters.com/business/energy/national-grid-warns-ai-driven-demand-pressure-2025-12-16/>

## **DOE National Laboratories & Science**

**Fermilab** — *Fermilab names Norbert Holtkamp as new director*  
[https://www.fnal.gov/pub/presspass/press\\_releases/Holtkamp-Director-2025.html](https://www.fnal.gov/pub/presspass/press_releases/Holtkamp-Director-2025.html)

**American Nuclear Society** — *Thea Energy completes Helios fusion plant design*  
<https://www.ans.org/news/2025-12-16/article-7624/thea-energy-helios-fusion-design/>

**Oak Ridge National Laboratory** — *ORNL partners with University of Tennessee on quantum materials research*  
<https://www.ornl.gov/news/ornl-ut-quantum-materials-exascale>

**Sandia National Laboratories** — *Sandia advances materials for hypersonic flight*  
<https://www.sandia.gov/news/publications/hypersonic-materials-research/>

**Lawrence Livermore National Laboratory** — *Virgin Galactic partners with LLNL on high-altitude imaging research*  
<https://www.llnl.gov/news/virgin-galactic-partners-llnl-imaging>

## **Nuclear Energy**

**Nuclear Regulatory Commission** — *NRC approves Browns Ferry license extensions*  
<https://www.nrc.gov/reading-rm/doc-collections/news/2025/browns-ferry-license-extension.html>

## **Environmental Management & Nuclear Waste**

**DOE Office of Environmental Management** — *DOE extends WIPP management contract*  
<https://www.energy.gov/em/articles/doe-extends-wipp-management-contract>

**Defense Nuclear Facilities Safety Board** — *DNFSB identifies risks at Hanford vitrification plant*

<https://www.dnfsb.gov/news/hanford-vitrification-bottleneck-report>